

1950

The Turing Test

July: Zuse's Z4

Konrad Zuse, whom we've mentioned in chapter 1, leased his Z4 computer in July to the ETH Zurich, a well-known university, making the Z4 the first commercial computer. Zuse, in addition to his computers, including the Z3, also designed the first high-level programming language, the Plankalkül, and founded the first “computer start-up.”

The Evolution Of Code

Programming languages are divided mainly into two types—low-level and high-level, depending on the level of abstraction. Roughly speaking, low-level languages, like assembly language, speak to the processor more directly—they address the actual hardware: registers, memory locations, and so on. High-level languages (C, C++, Java, etc.) refer to abstract elements like variables, arrays, and Boolean expressions. High-level languages are used to write easy-to-understand code; low-level languages for writing more efficient code.

October: The Turing Test

Alan Turing introduced the “Turing Test” in his paper titled “Computing Machinery and Intelligence.” In simple terms, if a human judge cannot distinguish between a computer and another human while interacting with them, the computer is said to have passed the Turing Test. Turing predicted that by 2000, computers would pass the Test. There have been various programs that have demonstrated some amount of humanlike behaviour, but no computer has thus far passed the Turing Test.